

3.2.2 2B Christianity

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Christianity specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Christianity
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought).

Section A: Christianity

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Bible: different Christian beliefs about the nature and authority of the Bible and their impact on its use as a source of beliefs and teachings, including the Bible as inspired by God but written by human beings.
- The Church: the different perspectives of the Protestant and Catholic traditions on the relative authority of the Bible and the Church.
- The authority of Jesus: different Christian understandings of Jesus' authority, including Jesus' authority as God's authority and Jesus' authority as only human; implications of these beliefs for Christian responses to Jesus' teaching and his value as a role model with reference to his teaching on retaliation and love for enemies in the Sermon on the Mount: Matthew 5:38–48.

God

- Christian Monotheism: one God, omnipotent creator and controller of all things; transcendent and unknowable; the doctrine of the Trinity and its importance; the meaning and significance of the belief that Jesus is the son of God; the significance of John 10:30; 1 Corinthians 8:6
- God as Personal, God as Father and God as Love: the challenge of understanding anthropomorphic and gender specific language about God: God as Father and King, including Christian feminist perspectives.
- The concept of God in process theology: God as neither omnipotent nor creator.

Self, death and afterlife

- The meaning and purpose of life: the following purposes and their relative importance: to glorify God and have a personal relationship with him; to prepare for judgement; to bring about God's kingdom on earth.
- Resurrection: the concept of soul; resurrection of the flesh as expressed in the writings of Augustine; spiritual resurrection; the significance of 1 Corinthians 15:42-44 and 50-54.
- Different interpretations of judgement, heaven, hell and purgatory as physical, spiritual or psychological realities; objective immortality in process thought.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in the Christian way of life, including reference to teaching about justification by works, justification by faith and predestination.
- Sanctity of life: the concept of sanctity of life; different views about its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child; the just war theory and its application to the use of weapons of mass destruction.
- Dominion and stewardship: the belief that Christians have dominion over animals; beliefs about the role of Christians as stewards of animals and the natural environment and how changing understandings of the effects of human activities on the environment have affected that role.

Expressions of religious identity

- Baptism: the significance of infant baptism in Christianity with particular reference to the Catholic and Baptist traditions; arguments in favour of and against infant baptism.
- Holy Communion: differing practices associated with Holy Communion, and differing understandings of Holy Communion and its importance, in the Catholic and Baptist

Churches; different Christian understandings of the significance of Jesus' actions at the last supper, Luke 22:17–20.

- The mission of the Church: developments in Christian ideas of 'mission' from the early 20th century to today.

Christianity, gender and sexuality

Historical and social factors that have influenced developments in Christian thinking about these issues including: the development of Biblical criticism, especially in the 19th century, and the resulting freedom to challenge traditional readings of passages such as 1 Tim 2:8-15; the changing roles of men and women in society outside of religion; the rights given to women by secular governments.

Developments in Christian thought, including feminist approaches:

- Debates about female ordination in the Church of England up to and after 1994, the continuing debate today.
- A comparison of the significant ideas of Daphne Hampson and Rosemary Radford Ruether about the patriarchal nature of Christianity including Hampson's view that Christianity is irredeemably sexist and Ruether's ideas about the androgynous Christ and her view that the female nature is more Christlike than the male.
- Different Christian views about celibacy, marriage, homosexuality and transgender issues.

Christianity and science

How and why science has influenced Christianity and how Christianity has responded, with particular reference to: emphasis on evidence and reason in science; specific scientific discoveries; science as a stimulus to Christian ethical thinking.

Developments in Christian thought:

- How scientific explanation has challenged Christian belief with reference to the 'God of the gaps'; 19th century Christian responses to Darwin's theory of evolution and contemporary responses to the Big Bang theory, including reference to creationist views.
- The belief that science is compatible with Christianity with reference to the views John Polkinghorne.
- Different Christian responses to issues raised by science: genetic engineering.

Christianity and the challenge of secularisation

This topic may be studied with exclusive reference to the British context.

The challenge of secularisation including the replacement of religion as the source of truth and moral values; relegation of religion to the personal sphere; the rise of militant atheism: the view that religion is irrational.

Developments in Christian thought:

- Responses to materialistic secular values: the value of wealth and possessions.
- McGrath's defence of Christianity in 'The Dawkins delusion'.
- Emergence of new forms of expression, such as Fresh Expressions and the House Church movement.
- Emphasis on the social relevance of Christianity including liberationist approaches as supporting the poor and defending the oppressed.

Christianity, migration and religious pluralism

How migration has created multicultural societies which include Christianity, with particular reference to the diversity of faiths in Britain today; freedom of religion as a human right in European law and religious pluralism as a feature of modern secular states. The influence of this context on Christian thought.

Developments in Christian thought:

- Christian attitudes to other faiths: Exclusivism with reference to John 14:6; Inclusivism with reference to the concept of 'anonymous Christians'; how Christian denominations view each other.
- Pluralism with reference to John Hick; its implications for interfaith and interdenominational relations.
- Christian responses to issues of freedom of religious expression in society.

Section B: Dialogues

This section of the specification is focused on the connections between various elements of the course and requires students to develop breadth and depth in their understanding of the connections between the knowledge, understanding and skills set out in the specification. There are two areas for study, firstly the dialogue between Christianity and philosophy: how developments in belief have, over time, influenced and been influenced by philosophical studies of religion, secondly the dialogue between Christianity and ethics: how developments in belief have influenced and been influenced by ethical studies.

Students will be required to demonstrate a critical awareness of these connections and to analyse their nature.

The dialogue between Christianity and philosophy

Beliefs and teachings about:

- God
- self, death and the afterlife
- sources of wisdom and authority
- religious experience
- the relationship between scientific and religious discourses
- the truth claims of other religions
- miracles.

The following issues, and the impact of the discussion on religious belief past and present, should be considered:

- How far the belief is reasonable – that is based on reason and/or consistent with reason.
- How meaningful the statements of faith are, and for whom.
- How coherent the beliefs are, and how consistent they are with other beliefs in the belief system.
- The relevance of philosophical enquiry for religious faith, with particular reference to the debate about the nature of faith as 'belief in' or 'belief that'.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.

The dialogue between Christianity and ethics

- Christian responses to the following approaches to moral decision-making in the light of key Christian moral principles:
 - deontological, with reference to Kant.
 - teleological and consequential, with reference to Bentham.
 - character based, with reference to virtue ethics.
- How far Christian ethics can be considered to be deontological, teleological, consequential, or character based.
- Christian responses to: the issues of human life and death and issues of animal life and death prescribed for study; theft and lying; marriage; homosexuality and transgender issues; genetic engineering.
- Christian responses to issues surrounding wealth, tolerance and freedom of religious expression.
- Christian understandings of free will and moral responsibility, and the value of conscience in Christian moral decision-making.

The impact of other ethical perspectives and ethical studies on Christian views about these issues, both past and present. This may include challenges to and support for Christian views; compatibility of Christian views with those of other ethical perspectives; the relative strengths and weaknesses of Christian perspectives and other ethical perspectives studied on these issues; the implications of criticisms of Christian ethical teaching for the religion as a whole and its sources of authority.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.